

Scraping the bottom of the barrel

WE'VE ALL PARTICIPATED in some pointless social media post or the other, at least once. And if you disagree with that, we're probably disagreeing on what you would term pointless, because you've participated in a few for sure.

If you're confused about the type of posts I'm talking about, they're usually the ones that are seriously stupid, such as, "Bet you don't know a city name that ends in T", or some silly math problem that's BODMAS related, or some other silly open-ended question about naming the #1 song the month and year you were born. Others might involve you selecting words associated with your birth date and month, prefixing those with the colour of your shirt, and then suffixing it with the last food item you ate, to arrive at your rapper name, or some utter nonsense like that.

And yes, I get that being Digit readers, you're all smart enough to know that these types of posts are pointless, and often used to scrape personal data about you. As Digit readers I already trust (hope?) that you're smart enough to make sure your passwords or security answers to absolutely everything you use, are never tied to personal information that can be extracted in these ways.

You know how scammers purposely write their emails badly, to weed out all of the smart people so that only the people more ignorant of their deviousness reply? The people who promote and post silly things on social media are doing the exact same thing. They don't care about trying to hack everyone's passwords or their accounts, they just want to get to the silliest 1% of people, because with a billion people to choose from that's still a target group of a million! They're scraping the bottom of the barrel, in a sense.

Services have been wising up and enforcing 2-factor authentication for everyone, so there's less chance that such data scraping results in actual financial losses, and we hope, in the future, we can finally put an end to such scams. (Wishful thinking?)

Still, the frequency of such posts never seems to die out. You will still always see one or two such posts that someone in your list of friends responded to, and inevitably more and more people end up clicking. I

know I do this often too. I usually go on to such posts and reply with my standard message, "Stop responding to such silly posts and revealing personal information." That way, when people who have me in their friend list see my response, they are less likely to take the bait – or so I hope.

If they're not really hacking people's passwords, or gathering personal data on them, what is their agenda? Why are so many pages collaborating to just keep people pointlessly engaged by asking stupid questions, all the time!

We tend to think of Cambridge Analytica, and companies like that who bend the rules and brainwash people into voting a certain way, and then charge their clients exorbitant fees for their services. It's the reason why social media companies themselves are worth all that money. You build something that even a 100 million people visit regularly and spend time on, people will throw money at you to be able to advertise to them. That's the legal way at least.

What these pages or handles do well is to bifurcate audiences into neat little categories based on the kind of content they put out and which they rank for. Then they'll pepper the content with just the right amount of controversial stuff to weed out any stragglers. For instance, in the US transgender rights are a touchy subject, so a post for or against them on the appropriate page will weed out the members who disagree with the majority.

What you have left is a nice engaging page with all of the right kind of people who are ripe for some disinformation, even if it's just in the comments and not in the post content itself, and then the snowball effect does the rest. Like the movie Inception tried to explain, an idea takes hold in the brain the strongest when the person thinks the idea is his or her own, rather than one that's obviously implanted there from an external source. This is exactly what these groups attempt to do.

The next time you're tempted to partake in something asinine, take a look at that page instead, look at its past posts, follow the trail to try and figure out what its agenda is. It's just a different rabbit hole you'll dive into, but this one will be a tad more rewarding in the end. **d**



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